GRE Inference Question Checklist

Stated Facts vs Inferences, The Text-Boundary Rule, Common Distractors & 4-Step Verification

1. What a GRE Inference Question Actually Tests

An inference on the GRE is a statement that MUST be true based on the passage—not a creative guess or outside speculation.

Inference Parameter	GRE Definition of a Valid Inference	What a Valid Inference Is NOT
Logical Standard	Mathematically guaranteed by explicit statements in the passage	NOT a plausible, creative, or imaginative extrapolation
Outside Knowledge	Relies 100% strictly on text evidence provided in the passage	NOT based on real-world facts from science, history, or business
Degree of Certainty	Must be undeniably true even in the most conservative scenario	NOT something that is "probably" or "likely" true
Typical Question Stems	"The passage implies...", "It can be inferred that...", "The author suggests..."	Requires finding where the author implicitly defined a boundary

Core Philosophy: The correct inference is the most modest, conservative, and unassailable answer choice.

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2. The 4-Step Evidence-Based Inference Solving Method

Follow this repeatable framework to solve dense academic inferences without second-guessing.

Step in Method	Action to Execute	Analytical Shorthand	Trap to Avoid
Step 1: Decode the Prompt	Identify the specific subject entity the question asks about	Circle entity name on scratchpad	Answering based on general passage recall
Step 2: Locate Exact Text Proof	Scan passage for the target entity; read 1 sentence before and after	Highlight exact textual boundary lines	Relying on memory rather than re-reading the evidence lines
Step 3: Pre-phrase the Necessary Implication	Ask: "If the passage says X, what must logically follow?"	Formulate a conservative deduction	Looking at answer choices before establishing proof
Step 4: Eliminate Distractors by Boundary	Reject choices that introduce outside words, extreme tones, or reversed logic	Eliminate 4 flawed options ruthlessly	Selecting an answer because you personally agree with it

Rule of Thumb: If an answer choice cannot be proven by pointing to a specific sentence in the text, it is WRONG.

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3. Top 4 Distractor Archetypes in GRE Inference Questions

Learn to recognize and eliminate flawed answer choices designed to mislead hurried readers.

- Distractor 1: The "Too Extreme" Choice. Contains absolute words like "always", "never", "only", "completely", or "solely" not supported by text.
- Distractor 2: The "Out-of-Scope Comparison". Asserts that Entity A is "more effective" or "larger" than Entity B when the text never compared them.
- Distractor 3: The "True in Real Life, Untrue in Text" Trap. A scientifically accurate statement that is nowhere mentioned or implied in the passage.
- Distractor 4: The "Reverse Causality" Trap. Flipping cause and effect (e.g. text says rain causes mud; choice asserts mud causes rain).